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- Twenty-five of Go First's A320neo jets had to be grounded after problems surfaced in their engines supplied by the US firm Pratt & Whitney
- Pratt & Whitney alleges the airline has defaulted on payment obligations; Go First says the engine supplier is not abiding by a Singapore arbitration court order to compensate it
- Most Indian airlines are undercapitalised, and Go First is no exception
- Covid further dented Go First's finances, and in just three financial years—FY21, FY22 and FY23—its losses mounted to Rs 4,000 crore, according to industry estimates
- The airline owes Rs 6,251 crore to a consortium of lenders led by the Central Bank of India. With half its fleet grounded, the airline will find it difficult to fund its remaining operations and service its debt, say experts

The May 2 decision of Go First, India's third-largest carrier, to suspend flights for two days—later extended till May 19—caught fliers, the aviation regulator and the Centre totally off guard. So did its move to file for voluntary insolvency proceedings before the Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT). The company has cited the long delays in sourcing airworthy engines from the US aerospace major Pratt & Whitney as the reason behind the decision to go for insolvency, but experts say the real issues go far beyond engine troubles, and point to financial problems at the airline and systemic issues in Indian aviation that will see most airlines flying through a turbulent phase in the days ahead. Indian airlines have reported consolidated losses of close to $17 billion (Rs 1.4 lakh crore) since FY2010, says CAPA Advisory, an aviation consulting firm. On May 10, the NCLT admitted Go First's plea, offering it protection against any immediate attachment of its assets by the company's lessors and lenders.

The crisis at the Wadia Group-owned airline, which employs 6,700 people, comes four years after the grounding of Jet Airways in 2019, and amid intense competition among airlines for a larger piece of the pie as the demand for air travel rises. Jet Airways had close to 16,000 staffers when it went into the insolvency process, and the plans of a consortium of bidders to revive it have not taken off yet. The NCLT order comes as a temporary relief for Go First, but a revival of the airline will be an arduous process, with half its aircraft grounded and financial position sticky. "If they (Go First) can come up with some funds and somehow resolve the matter with the lessors,